

FIRST TAG GUIDES

Your Digital Hunt Camp

BEGINNER'S GUIDE SERIES

A BEGINNER'S COMPLETE GUIDE TO Whitetail Deer Hunting

From Your First Stand to Your First Harvest — Own Your Prep.

7 CHAPTERS | FIELD-READY GUIDE | firsttagguides.com



Welcome to the Tradition. It's one worth Preserving.

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Always Hunt Legally & Safely | Check Local Regulations | © First Tag Guides

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Each chapter is built around one goal: making sure you step into the field prepared, legal, and confident. The Quick Reference Cheat Sheet at the back is yours to print, laminate, and carry.

Author's Introduction

By Colin — First Tag Guides

There's a certain stillness in the whitetail woods that you don't find anywhere else. It's not silence, exactly — it's a deeper kind of quiet. The kind that forces you to slow down, pay attention, and let the noise of the world fall away.

I remember one morning when the frost was thick on the grass and every breath hung in the air like smoke. I'd been in the stand for hours — cold, stiff, questioning whether I should have stayed in bed — when I caught the faint crunch of hooves behind me. A buck, cautious and deliberate, moving like a ghost through the timber. My heart was pounding, hands frozen, every sense wide open. I didn't get a shot that day. But I was there. And sometimes, being there is the whole point.

Whitetail hunting, for me, isn't about what ends up on the wall. It's about learning how to sit with stillness, how to move with purpose, and how to become part of the landscape instead of just passing through it. It teaches you how to work for something that won't always pay off. It humbles you. And if you let it, it changes you.

Like most hunters, I started on family property and public land — cheap gear, cold mornings, and more misses than I care to count. Through all of it, I found something real. Something worth getting up for, worth working toward, and worth passing on.

This guide is for anyone who wants to do more than just hunt deer. It's for the person who wants to understand them. To chase them with respect. To be part of the cycle, not just the shot. If you're new to this — welcome. You're not just entering a season. You're stepping into something older than fences, tags, or technology.

Welcome to the Tradition. It's one worth Preserving.

— Colin

CHAPTER ONE

Essential Gear

What You Need, What Helps, and What to Skip for Now

"You don't need to spend a fortune to start deer hunting. But showing up unprepared will cost you more than money — it will cost you the hunt."

The Must-Haves

These are the items every deer hunter needs on Day One. No exceptions.

- **Your Weapon**

Rifle (common calibres: .270, .308, or .30-06) or compound bow. Practice with the exact ammunition or arrows you plan to hunt with — consistency matters.

- **Hunting Licence & Tags**

Check your provincial regulations for exactly what's required. Always carry your paperwork or a digital copy. Hunting without it isn't an option.

- **Clothing & Layers**

Base layers for warmth — wool or synthetic, never cotton. Outer layers in a muted colour or camo pattern that suits your terrain. Waterproof boots with good ankle support.

- **Blaze Orange (Firearm Season)**

In most provinces, a hat and vest or jacket in blaze orange is legally required during firearm season. Deer are largely red-green colour blind — it doesn't spook them. Wear it.

- **A Sharp Knife**

Fixed-blade or quality folding knife for field dressing. Sharp is safe. A dull knife slips.

- **A Day Pack**

Carry your water, snacks, gloves, knife, drag rope, headlamp, and first aid kit. Keep it simple and keep it organized.

- **Binoculars**

Mid-range glass — 8x42 or 10x42 — for spotting movement at a distance without closing the gap and blowing your cover.

Helpful Add-Ons

These aren't required on Day One, but they earn their place once you have the basics dialled in.

- **Rangefinder**

Takes the guesswork out of distance. Helps you make ethical shot decisions.

- **Deer Calls**

A grunt tube or bleat can. Simple, affordable, and effective during the rut.

- **Hand and Toe Warmers**

Non-negotiable in cold climates. Cold hands make for poor decisions.

- **Trail Camera**

Useful for off-season scouting. Lets the camera do the work while you stay out of the area.

- **Drag Rope or Deer Sled**

You'll be grateful you brought one. Moving a harvested deer without one is a workout you didn't plan for.

- **Seat Cushion or Therm-a-Seat**

Keeps you warmer and quieter in a stand or blind. Comfort keeps you in the woods longer.

Overbuying before you understand what you actually need is one of the most common first-season mistakes. Focus on the essentials first. Upgrade as you learn what your style of hunting actually demands. Equally important: make sure your boots fit properly and your clothing moves quietly. Blisters end hunts. Noisy fabric gives you away. Get those two things right before anything else.

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- Invest in the essentials first: weapon, licence, layers, boots, knife, and a basic pack.
 - Never wear cotton as a base layer. It holds moisture and will make you cold fast.
 - Blaze orange is legally required in most provinces during firearm season. Wear it.
 - A rangefinder and deer calls are useful additions — but not Day One priorities.
 - Well-fitted boots and quiet clothing will do more for your hunt than any gadget.

“Good boots and a sharp knife. Start there. Everything else can wait.”

— First Tag Guides

CHAPTER TWO

Scouting Basics

Learning the Land Before You Hunt It

"Before you hunt, you scout. Scouting is where real success starts — even before the season opens. The hunter who knows the land will almost always outperform the one who doesn't."

What You're Looking For

You're reading a story the deer have been writing all season. Here's what their sign looks like on the ground:

- **Tracks**

Hoof prints in mud, snow, or soft soil. Fresh tracks are sharp and well-defined. Older ones are weathered, dry, or crumbling at the edges.

- **Droppings**

Small, dark, pellet-like droppings near feeding and bedding areas. Confirms recent deer activity.

- **Rubs**

Bucks scrape the velvet from their antlers on saplings and small trees. Look for bark rubbed off between one and three feet from the ground. Fresh rubs have bright, pale wood exposed.

- **Scrapes**

Oval patches of bare earth where a buck has pawed the ground, usually beneath an overhanging branch called a licking branch. One of the most reliable signs of mature buck activity, especially as the rut approaches.

- **Trails**

Deer follow the same paths between food, water, and bedding areas repeatedly. These trails appear as narrow, worn lines in the vegetation or leaf cover. Find the trail; understand the pattern.

Where to Scout

Focus your energy on these three areas:

- **Bedding Areas**

Thick, brushy cover where deer feel safe from predators and pressure. South-facing slopes in cold weather. Once you've located them, stay out — don't burn them before the season opens.

- **Feeding Areas**

Agricultural fields (corn, soybeans, clover), acorn-producing oak stands, or food plots. Deer need to eat. Find the food and you'll find the deer.

- **Travel Corridors**

Funnels, ridges, creek crossings, fence gaps — anywhere terrain naturally narrows deer movement into a predictable path. These are prime stand locations.

Scouting Tools

You don't need to put boots on the ground to start building your picture of the land. Apps like onX Hunt, HuntStand, and Google Earth give you topographic overlays — that's a map showing the shape and elevation of the terrain — along with property boundaries and satellite imagery. Mark saddles (low points between two ridges where deer travel), pinch points (narrow corridors), and water sources before you ever make the drive.

If you're using trail cameras, place them over active scrapes or on trails leading to food sources. Wear scent-free gloves when handling and checking cameras. Check them as infrequently as possible — every intrusion is pressure on the area. Let the camera work so you don't have to.

Don't just hunt where deer are — hunt where they'll be when conditions are right. Wind direction, time of day, hunting pressure, and phase of the season all affect where deer move. A trail that's hot in October may be cold in November. Read the sign, understand the pattern, and adjust. The land will tell you what you need to know if you pay attention.

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- Scouting is the process of learning how deer use the land. It starts before the season and never really stops.
 - The four key signs: tracks, rubs, scrapes, and trails. Learn to read them.
 - Focus on three areas: bedding, feeding, and the corridors between them.
 - E-scouting with apps like onX Hunt lets you study the land from your kitchen. Use it.
 - Stay out of bedding areas once you've located them. Pressure changes deer patterns.
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“Scout the land like you’re reading a map that was drawn by the deer themselves.”

— First Tag Guides

CHAPTER THREE

Stand & Blind Placement

Putting Yourself in the Right Place for the Right Reason

"A mediocre stand in a great location will beat a great stand in a bad location every single time. Placement is everything."

Types of Setups

Choose the setup that fits your terrain, your comfort level, and your hunting style.

- **Hang-On Tree Stand**

Quiet, versatile, and well-suited to permanent setups. Requires separate climbing sticks to access. Good option once you've found a productive location.

- **Climbing Stand**

Portable and repositionable. Requires a straight, branch-free tree. Great for hunters who like to move and adapt.

- **Ladder Stand**

Easy to get in and out of, stable, and beginner-friendly. Less portable but excellent for a reliable, returning spot.

- **Ground Blind**

Keeps you low and concealed. Ideal for field edges, open terrain, or bowhunting. Brush it in with natural local vegetation to break up its shape and help it blend.

Wind: Your Number One Consideration

Deer rely on their nose more than their eyes or ears. If your scent reaches them before you see them, the hunt is over before it started. Always set up downwind of where you expect deer to approach from. Carry a small wind-checker — a puffer bottle of odourless powder, or even a few milkweed seeds — and use it frequently. If the wind shifts in the wrong direction, leave the stand. One blown stand is better than educating every deer in the area.

Bad wind equals a bad hunt. Don't rationalize it. If the wind is wrong for your stand, either have a backup stand with a better wind option or go home and come back when conditions are right. Hunting into the wind is non-negotiable.

Ideal Stand Locations

- **Just off trails, not directly on them**

Deer tend to avoid standing directly on a heavily used trail. Set up slightly to the side.

- **Downwind of scrapes, rub lines, or feeding areas**

Put yourself where you can observe the sign without your scent alerting the deer first.

- **Natural funnels and pinch points**

Anywhere terrain narrows deer movement — creek crossings, fence gaps, saddles between ridges — is a high-percentage location.

- **Field edges and transitions**

The seam between two types of cover — hardwoods to thicket, open timber to bedding — is where deer tend to linger.

Timing and Access

- **Set up early**

Install stands or blinds weeks before the season. Give deer time to accept them as part of the landscape.

- **Plan your entry and exit routes**

Getting to and from your stand without being detected is as important as where the stand is. Avoid crossing active deer trails. Use terrain features — creek bottoms, ditches, low ground — to conceal your approach.

- **Arrive before first light**

Use a red or green light in the dark. White light disrupts your night vision and can spook deer. Move slowly and quietly.

- **Rotate your stands**

Don't overhunt one spot. Give locations a rest, especially after you've been detected. Pressure educates deer faster than almost anything else.

The single most common stand placement mistake is setting up too close to the road or parking area. Every hunter who has walked into that piece of land has made the same calculation, and the deer have been educated by that accumulated pressure. Be willing to walk further than everyone else. Hunting pressure drops off dramatically beyond the first half kilometre from a road.

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- Wind is your number one consideration. Set up downwind of where you expect deer to approach.
 - If the wind shifts wrong, leave the stand. One ruined sit is better than ruining the spot.
 - Set up stands weeks before the season to let deer acclimate to them.
 - Plan entry and exit routes as carefully as you plan your stand location.
 - Rotate stands to avoid burning them out through overhunting.
 - A good location with a mediocre stand beats a great stand in the wrong place.

“The stand is just the seat. The location is the strategy.”

— First Tag Guides

CHAPTER FOUR

Shot Placement & Tracking

Making Clean, Ethical Shots and Recovering Your Animal

"When everything lines up — the scouting, the setup, the wind — you have one job left: make a clean, ethical shot. Everything in this chapter exists to help you do that."

Where to Aim

The goal of every shot is the same: deliver your bullet or arrow into the vital zone — the heart and lungs — as quickly and cleanly as possible. The vital zone on a whitetail sits in the chest cavity, directly behind the front shoulder.

- **Broadside — The Gold Standard**

The deer is standing perpendicular to you. Aim at the lower third of the body, directly behind the front leg. Maximum target area, maximum margin for error.

- **Quartering-Away — Highly Effective**

The deer is angled away from you. Aim at the near-side last rib and visualize the path through the chest toward the off-side shoulder. One of the most forgiving presentations.

- **Quartering-Toward — Use Caution**

The chest cavity is partially blocked by the near shoulder. For a first-season hunter, the right call is usually to wait for the deer to turn.

- **Straight-On or Straight-Away — Pass**

Target area is minimal, margin for error is near zero. Be patient. The deer will rarely hold that position for long.

Shooting Fundamentals

- **Steady your position**

Use a shooting stick, bipod, or tree rest. A supported shot is a confident shot.

- **Control your breathing**

Exhale and pause at the natural bottom of your breath before squeezing the trigger or releasing.

- **Follow through**

Stay on the target after the shot. Don't drop your head or pull off early.

- **Know your range**

Use a rangefinder. Know your effective distance and don't exceed it.

- **Practice before the season**

Muscle memory is built at the range. Arrive at your stand having already made this shot a hundred times.

After the Shot

What you do in the first few minutes after the shot matters as much as the shot itself.

- **Stay put**

Mark the exact spot where the deer was standing. Watch the direction it ran and note how it reacted to the shot.

- **Wait before following**

For a confirmed lung hit, thirty minutes is adequate. For a less certain reaction, wait four to six hours. A suspected gut shot — green material or foul odour on the arrow or ground — requires at least eight hours. A pressured, gut-shot deer will run. An unpressured one will lie down.

- **Read the blood**

Bright frothy blood indicates a lung hit. Dark red blood typically means heart. Sparse or intermittent sign requires patience and a methodical search.

If You Lose the Trail

- **Mark the last known blood**

Use flagging tape or a stick so you can return to your last confirmed point.

- **Slow down and get low**

Blood on grass or low vegetation is often invisible from standing height.

- **Grid the area**

Search in widening circles from the last blood. Deer often bed within sight of where the trail went cold.

- **Ask for help**

More eyes find more deer. Call someone in if you need to.

Taking a rushed shot, a long-distance guess, or a shot through heavy brush are among the most common first-season errors — and the most consequential. A poor shot means a lost or wounded animal, and that is the outcome every ethical hunter works to avoid. If you don't have a clear, confident shot at the vitals, don't take it. The deer will come back. The chance will come again.

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- Aim for the heart-lung zone behind the front shoulder. Broadside is the gold standard.
 - Quartering-away is a strong second option. Pass on straight-on and straight-away shots.
 - Steady your position, control your breathing, and follow through.
 - After the shot: stay put, mark the location, wait before following.
 - Bright frothy blood means lungs. Dark heavy blood means heart. Green material means wait longer.
 - If you lose the trail, slow down, get low, and be methodical.

“A well-placed shot is the most respectful thing you can offer the animal.”

— First Tag Guides

CHAPTER FIVE

Field Dressing & Transport

Taking Care of the Animal Once It's Down

"Field dressing is awkward and humbling the first time. It gets easier. But every time, it should feel like it matters — because it does."

What You'll Need

- **Sharp knife**
Fixed-blade or quality folding. Sharp is safe.
- **Nitrile or rubber gloves**
At least two pairs. Hygiene and safety.
- **Drag rope or deer sled**
You'll need to move the animal. Plan for it.
- **Headlamp**
If you're working in the dark.
- **Game bags**
Breathable mesh. Not plastic — plastic traps heat and accelerates spoilage.
- **Paper towels or clean cloth**
For wiping out the body cavity.

Step by Step

Work slowly. Work carefully. This is a skill that improves with repetition.

- **Step 1: Confirm the animal is expired.**
Approach from behind. Touch the open eye with a stick — no blink reflex means the animal is down. If uncertain, wait. Never assume.
- **Step 2: Tag the animal.**
Once you have confirmed the animal is down, validate and attach your tag as required by provincial regulations. Before photos, before field dressing, before moving the animal.
- **Step 3: Position the deer.**
On its back, hindquarters slightly downhill if terrain allows. This helps with drainage.
- **Step 4: Make the initial incision.**
Begin at the base of the sternum — the bottom of the ribcage. Insert the knife tip upward, away from the stomach contents below. Draw the blade toward the pelvis using two fingers as a guide to avoid puncturing the gut.
- **Step 5: Open the chest cavity.**
Use your knife or a small folding bone saw to open the ribcage. This allows airflow and gives you access to the heart and lungs.

- **Step 6: Sever the windpipe and esophagus.**

Reach as far forward into the chest as you can and cut both as close to the jaw as possible. This allows you to pull the entire organ system free as one unit.

- **Step 7: Remove the organs.**

Pull the windpipe rearward, cutting the diaphragm — the thin wall between the chest and abdomen — free on both sides. The gut pile should come out as a connected unit.

- **Step 8: Wipe and air the cavity.**

Wipe out remaining blood and prop the cavity open with a clean stick for airflow. If temperatures are above 4°C, get the animal cooled quickly.

Temperature Management

Heat is the enemy of meat quality. The faster you cool the carcass, the better the table fare. In warm early-season conditions, get the animal into shade immediately and consider quartering it in the field to maximize surface area. Never use plastic bags for meat transport. Use breathable game bags.

The first time you dress a deer is the hardest. After that, it becomes part of the experience. Stay calm, work slowly, and remember: taking proper care of the animal is not a chore at the end of the hunt. It is the fulfillment of it. Prepare for this process before the season opens so it isn't your first time figuring it out in fading light.

Rushing through field dressing out of excitement, or delaying it because you're unsure what to do, both lead to the same outcome: compromised meat. An undressed deer in warm temperatures begins to spoil from the inside out faster than most beginners realize. Know the steps before you need them. The animal deserves your preparedness, not your improvisation.

-
- Tag the animal first. Before photos. Before anything else.
 - Confirm the animal is fully expired before approaching.
 - Work from the sternum toward the pelvis without puncturing the gut.
 - Sever the windpipe as far forward as possible and remove organs as one connected unit.
 - Prop the cavity open for airflow. Never use plastic bags for meat transport.
 - In warm conditions, cool the carcass quickly. Consider quartering in the field.

“Taking care of the animal after the shot is not the end of the hunt. It is the fulfillment of it.”

— First Tag Guides

CHAPTER SIX

Safety, Ethics & Regulations

Hunting Legally, Safely, and With Respect

"A successful hunt doesn't just mean venison in the freezer. It means doing it right — safely, legally, and in a way you'd be proud to talk about."

Firearm and Archery Safety

These rules are non-negotiable. There are no exceptions.

- **Treat every weapon as if it's loaded.**
Always. Every time.
- **Point your muzzle in a safe direction.**
Know where it is at all times.
- **Keep your finger off the trigger until ready to shoot.**
Outside the trigger guard until your sights are on target.
- **Know your target and what's beyond it.**
A projectile doesn't stop at the animal.
- **Unload before climbing, crossing obstacles, or entering a vehicle.**
No exceptions.

Always use a haul line to raise and lower your firearm or bow to and from your tree stand. Never carry your weapon while climbing. This is one of the most important safety habits a tree stand hunter can build.

Tree Stand Safety

- **Wear a full-body safety harness.**
Every time you leave the ground. This is not optional.
- **Use a lifeline system.**
A continuous rope from the ground to your stand allows you to be connected at every point of your climb.
- **Inspect your stand every season.**
Weather, UV exposure, and animals degrade straps and hardware. Check everything before you trust it with your life.

Understanding the Regulations

Visit your provincial wildlife agency's website before the season opens. Regulations change. Read them fresh every year. The key areas to know:

- **Licensing**

Carry your hunting licence, tags, and ID at all times afield.

- **Seasons**

Hunt only during legal firearm or archery seasons for your zone.

- **Tagging**

Immediately tag your deer before moving it. This is law, not suggestion.

- **Weapon restrictions**

Know what firearms and archery equipment are legal in your area for your specific season.

- **Land access**

Get written permission for private land. Know the rules for any public land you hunt.

Hunting Ethics

The law tells you what is legal. Ethics tells you what is right. They are not always the same thing. Before you take a shot, before you enter a piece of land, ask yourself: is this fair chase? Am I giving the animal a reasonable opportunity? Would I be proud to tell this story at the camp table?

- **Take clean, ethical shots.**

Don't shoot beyond your skill or your range.

- **Recover every animal.**

Do not walk away from a hit deer without an exhaustive search.

- **Respect property and boundaries.**

Posted signs exist for a reason.

- **Leave no trace.**

Pack out trash, casings, gloves, and field dressing remnants.

Hunt like someone is watching — because your actions represent every hunter who came before you and every one who will come after. The reputation of this tradition is built one hunter at a time. Take pride in doing it right.

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- The four firearm safety rules apply every time, without exception.
 - Wear a full-body harness every time you leave the ground. Use a haul line for your weapon.
 - Read your provincial regulations fresh every season. They change.
 - Tag your deer immediately before moving it. This is law.
 - Ethics and legality are not the same thing. Hold yourself to the higher standard.
 - Your actions represent all hunters. Hunt with that responsibility in mind.

“Hunt like someone’s watching. Because your actions represent all of us.”

— First Tag Guides

CHAPTER SEVEN

Common Beginner Mistakes

What Most First-Timers Get Wrong — and How to Avoid It

"Every hunter learns by making mistakes. But you can skip a few of the most expensive ones by knowing what to watch for before your first season."

Ignoring the Wind

This is the biggest mistake in deer hunting, full stop. Deer live by their noses. If your scent reaches them before you see them, the hunt is over. Check your wind direction before you leave for your stand and continuously while you're in it. Carry a wind checker. Hunt downwind of where you expect deer. If the wind shifts wrong, leave.

Overhunting One Spot

Hunting the same stand every day educates the deer using that area. Rotate between stands when possible. Give locations a rest after a hunt, especially if you were detected. A well-rested stand on the right wind beats a burned-out spot on a perfect morning.

Moving Too Much

Fidgeting, constantly turning your head, and making unnecessary adjustments will give you away. Practice sitting still for extended periods before the season opens. When you do need to move, do it slowly and smoothly. Break up your silhouette with natural cover or your camo pattern.

Hunting at the Wrong Time

Midday sits are often slow, particularly in the early season. The most productive windows are first light and the last hour of daylight. Deer movement also increases in the hours before a weather change — watch the forecast and plan your sits accordingly.

Taking Poor Shots

Rushing, shooting at distances beyond your practiced range, or firing through brush are all decisions that result in wounded deer and lost animals. If you don't have a clear, confident shot at the vitals, don't take it. The deer will move. The opportunity will come. Practice at hunting distances before the season and know your effective range cold.

Underestimating Scent

Deer can smell you from hundreds of metres away under the right conditions. Wash your hunting clothes in unscented detergent and store them away from everyday odours. Avoid handling food, stopping at fuel stations, or using strong deodorant in your hunting clothes. Hunt the wind first. Scent management is the second layer of defence, not the first.

Getting Discouraged

You may not see a deer in your first week. You may not harvest one in your first season. That is not failure — that is hunting. Every experienced hunter in the tradition has a pile of slow seasons behind them. What separates the ones who stayed from the ones who quit is simple: they kept showing up. Each sit teaches you something. Each morning in the field makes you better.

Even a slow day in the woods teaches you something. The wind. The light. How the deer moved and where you were when they did. Keep a small notebook and write it down. That log becomes your scouting report. Keep showing up — that's how hunters are made.

The biggest mistake of all is expecting instant results and walking away when they don't come. Patience is not a passive skill in deer hunting — it is an active, practiced discipline. The tradition rewards the hunters who stay in the stand one hour longer, who come back to the same piece of ground season after season, and who treat every sit as a lesson worth showing up for.

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- Wind is the biggest factor. Check it before and during every hunt. Leave if it turns wrong.
 - Rotate your stands. Overhunting one spot educates deer and burns the location.
 - Stillness is concealment. Practice sitting quietly before the season.
 - First light and last light are your best windows. Plan your sits around them.
 - If you don't have a clear shot at the vitals, don't take it. Wait for a better opportunity.
 - Hunt the wind first. Scent control is the second layer, not the first.
 - Stay patient. Success in this tradition is built over seasons, not sits.
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“Even a slow day in the woods teaches you something. Keep showing up.”

— First Tag Guides

Quick Reference Cheat Sheet

Print it, laminate it, or save it to your phone. This is your field reference.

Day Hunt Essentials

- ✓ Weapon (Rifle or Bow)
- ✓ Ammo / Arrows
- ✓ Knife
- ✓ Binoculars
- ✓ Licence & Tags
- ✓ Water & Snacks
- ✓ Gloves / Hat / Warm Layers
- ✓ Headlamp
- ✓ Drag Rope or Sled
- ✓ Phone / Map / Compass
- ✓ First Aid Kit

Scouting Signs

Tracks — Fresh = sharp edges. Old = crumbling.

Rubs — Bark scraped from saplings. Buck sign.

Scrapes — Bare dirt under a licking branch.

Trails — Worn paths between bedding and food.

Wind Rules

- Always hunt downwind of expected deer approach.
- Use a wind checker frequently.
- If the wind is wrong — leave the stand.

Shot Placement

Broadside — Aim behind the front shoulder, lower third.

Quartering-Away — Aim at near-side last rib, drive through.

Quartering-Toward — Wait for a better angle.

Straight-On / Away — Pass. Wait for a broadside opportunity.

After the Shot

- Watch impact and direction of travel.
- Wait: 30 min (lung), 4–6 hrs (uncertain), 8+ hrs (gut).
- Mark last blood before moving.
- Follow the trail slowly and methodically.

Field Dressing Steps

1. Confirm the animal is expired.
2. Tag the deer.
3. Cut from sternum to pelvis — don't puncture the gut.
4. Sever windpipe, remove organs as one unit.
5. Wipe cavity and prop open for airflow.
6. Cool the meat quickly.

Beginner Don'ts

- ✗ Hunt with the wind at your back.
- ✗ Overhunt one stand.
- ✗ Take rushed or uncertain shots.
- ✗ Skip scouting.
- ✗ Give up too soon.

FIRST TAG GUIDES

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You made it through. That already puts you ahead of where most people start.

Everything in this guide — the gear, the scouting, the shot, the field dressing — is knowledge that was passed down before it reached you. That's the nature of this tradition. It doesn't belong to any one person. It belongs to the people willing to carry it forward.

Your first season will not be perfect. You will sit in the wrong spot, spook animals you never saw, and come home some mornings having learned nothing except that tomorrow is another chance. That is hunting. That has always been hunting.

Hunt ethically. Hunt legally. Take care of what you harvest. Share what you learn. The door at First Tag is always open.

Welcome to the Tradition. It's one worth Preserving.

— Colin | First Tag Guides

Always hunt legally. Always hunt safely. Check your provincial regulations every season.